Documents are forged by photoshopping photographs of the candidate from copies of their e-Aadhaar. The gang used one Raju Kumar, who would take Rs 2,000 for each picture he morphed. He has now been arrested in Varanasi and his computer seized. User names and passwords are also obtained to make necessary modifications to get the desired examination centre.

The candidates themselves do not meet their proxies. "Middlemen like PK or Shahid handle everything, right from identifying an aspirant to hiring the impersonator," says Ganesh. The proxies also do not appear for candidates from their own states. So Julie in Varanasi took the NEET for Sabita in Tripura, while DTU (Delhi Technological University) graduate Pradip Kumar wrote the 2020 JEE for Neel Nakshatra Das from Assam. Das secured 99.8 per cent marks and emerged as one of the toppers that year. The fame was short-lived—as the Assam police arrested Das and his doctor father in October 2020.

How the Crooks Crumbled

When interrogated, PK, Shahid and Singh confessed to arranging proxies for 25 aspirants for NEET 2021, although only 16 appeared as the rest developed cold feet and skipped the exam. The trio's bank accounts show several transactions from different entities over the past few years. The Varanasi police have also seized copies of 15 admit cards, four photos, four cargo courier receipts, and two phones containing incriminating chats from Shahid and PK and admit cards, OMR (optical mark reader) sheets, cheques of different amounts and other documents from Singh.

Though there is no specific data to tell us how deep the rot runs, anecdotal evidence suggests it is more a rule than an exception. Over the years, the Calcutta-based CFPB or the Centre Finger Print Bureau, which falls under the aegis of the NCRB or the National Crime Records Bureau, has also unearthed cases of impersonation in various recruitment tests conducted by the Punjab National Bank, the central paramilitary forces, and the ordnance factory board. According to the Varanasi police, the fingerprints on the entrance forms of the 16 candidates who had proxies appearing for NEET were found to be different from those on the answer sheets.

The Varanasi police—given their limited jurisdictional mandate—were able to check just a few of the examinees. The National Testing Agency later withheld the results of 15 aspirants and banned one from appearing in the exam for two years. The police have already made arrests in Patna, Varanasi and Lucknow in this case.

However, the malaise runs across the country—from UP to Bihar to Haryana to Rajasthan to Madhya Pradesh, and even Tamil Nadu. If Julie was arrested in Varanasi, the



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The racket includes coaching staff and agents who scout for medical students willing to play proxies and 'desperate' candidates ready to shell out Rs 50 lakh for their 'service'. A candidate seldom meets their proxies. Nor are they from the same state.

One group taps coaching centres to collect data on candidates from well-off families who failed to clear NEET in previous attempts. Another group works with senior MBBS students to identify bright 1st or 2nd-year medical students from financially weak backgrounds. Their families are contacted and an advance paid.

Once a parent agrees to hire a proxy for his ward, he or she pays an advance of Rs 5 lakh on the total deal of Rs 50 lakh. They also deposit post-dated cheques and original Class X and XII mark sheets of the candidates as security which are returned after the remainder is paid, usually after the candidate secures admission.



The photographs of both the candidate (**Sabita**) and her proxy (**Julie**) were altered in Photoshop, as above.